My Brother's Keeper

By Mike Resnick and Jack Nimershein

INTRODUCTION

The phrasing may differ, but the requests are always the same. And it is I who must respond to each summons, answer every request. Such is my duty; such is my curse.Damn! There's another one. Oh, well. No rest for the wicked—yet another idiom steeped in irony. My Brother's Keeper by Mike Resnick and Jack Nimershein

Kyle Patton felt extremely satisfied with himself as he swaggered down the sidewalk of West Holland Boulevard. The sun warmed his smiling face. A gentle breeze cooled the sweat from his tan, muscular body. He'd had a good day: a towering three-run homer in the bottom of the sixth inning that turned an anticipated defeat for his high-school baseball team into a surprise victory; the congratulations of his teammates; the gratitude of his coach; the cheers from a hometown crowd; Jenny Firth's promise to reward his heroics later that night with a special "surprise," provided he could

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borrow his father's Grand Cherokee and then find a nice, quiet, secluded spot out by Tucker's Pond.

Ripping off that dweeb's Starter jacket behind the bleachers after the game was mere icing on the cake of Kyle's insatiable ego. Of course, it would never fit him. Too small. Every fancy jacket he'd ever peeled off the quivering frame of a skinny underclassman was too small for him to wear. But then, wasn't that the point of the exercise? Who'd be so stupid as to pick on someone his own size? Or bigger? Certainly not Kyle, that was for damned sure.

Kyle was still swaggering, still smiling, when a large hand wrapped itself around his mouth and pulled him, none too gently, into the alleyway that separated Karen's Boutique from The Daily Grind Croissant and Expresso Shoppe. My hand.

"That's a nice jacket you're carrying, kid," I said. Kyle didn't know me from Adam—excuse me, make that from Cain—but he didn't have any trouble recognizing my threatening tone. (Why should he have? He'd spent endless

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hours perfecting a similar inflection in his own speech patterns.) "Looks a little small for you, though," I continued. "I wonder why that is?"

I released Kyle's mouth, grabbed his left shoulder, and spun him around.

"What do you want?" Kyle managed to stammer, stumbling even farther back into the shadows of the cramped alleyway. I'd heard that question so many hundreds, thousands, even millions of times.

"What I want is peace. And He'd grant it to me, if it weren't for punks like you. As long as you and your kind—my kind—exist, I remain here, an eternal balance to the scales. Since I can't have the peace I crave," I continued, my voice almost a whisper, "I must content myself with the retribution that He insists is my responsibility." I stepped toward Kyle, feeling the usual combination of rage and resignation welling up within me. "So get ready to cough up the jacket, kid, along with some blood and a couple of teeth from that perfect smile."

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A coat! Amazing, that the children of today visit harm upon one another over something as inconsequential as a coat. Other trivial objects trigger violence, as well. Last week—or maybe it was last month; Time has very little meaning at this late date—the call came from a playground. I materialized just as one child toppled another from the upper rungs of a ladder attached to a tall metal slide. I heard the smaller child's femur snap as he feel heavily to the asphalt. I saw the satisfaction in the larger child's eyes as he stared down at his victim, a cruel sneer playing across his young face. Those youthful features bore no sign of the innocence normally associated with adolescence, nor the slightest sign of regret for the pain he'd caused. Of course there wasn't. Otherwise, I would not have been summoned—although, now that I reflect upon it, "summoned" is probably not the right word. No disembodied voice issues forth from the heavens, demanding my presence. Rather, I'm drawn to youthful conflict, like a moth to the proverbial flame.

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My involvement is implied, not imposed. "Am I my brother's keeper?" Those are the very words I once used; the Bible got that right, anyway.

Give the Old Man credit. He possesses a marvelous sense of irony. Because now that is precisely what I am, what He made me. On my eternal shoulders rests the responsibility for defending those children who are too small, or too weak, or too frightened, or too meek, or too gentle, or too genteel, to defend themselves. A fearful child calls, and I respond. Whenever the big abuse the small, the strong mistreat the weak, I appear—always bigger, always stronger ("More ablebodied," He once proclaimed, again demonstrating the ironic wit few realize He possesses) to balance the scales.

The specifics of my appearance and abilities change continually, calculated each time to counterbalance the current circumstances, whatever they might be. The pattern of my intervention, however, remains constant. It is always the same. At least it was, until that day at the park.

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There were two big kids, almost men, in leather jackets, beating the hell out of a younger boy. I walked over, unseen. "That's enough," I said.

The larger of the boys turned and landed a roundhouse on my jaw. I didn't flinch.

"Don't you know that hurts?" I said, landing the same blow on his chin. He spun like a top, then collapsed. I grabbed the second boy by the throat and held him a few inches above the ground as he gasped for air, and then, for the first time, my eyes fell on the face of his victim.

I set the boy on his feet. "Go!" I said firmly.

"Thank you," said their victim.

I turned to him, and saw the face I had been sure I would never see again: the clear blue eyes, the perfect nose, the light blond hair.

"You!" I hissed. "That face has haunted me for millennia!" I said. "Every time I struck another child, it was you I was hitting. Every time I sent them running off into the dark, it was you! Why have you come to

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torment me? Why, after a thousand thousand generations? Why now?"

"I am not here to torment you," he said in the voice that still haunts my every moment. "You have paid your penalty. It is time to make your peace with God, and to rest."

"God has sent you?"

"How else could I be having this conversation with you, my brother?"

"And what does He want of me?" I asked.

"Only that you beg Him for His divine forgiveness."

"I begged Him for that ten million full moons ago," I said. "When I wandered cold and alone in the land of Nod, I confessed my guilt and asked for His mercy." I paused. "You see what it got me."

"Ask Him again," said my brother. "This time He will listen."

"Has He no memory of what I said?" I demanded. "Can God not recall my confession and my plea?"

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"He is God," said my brother, as if that answered everything.

"Then go to him and tell Him that He must ask for my forgiveness, for the punishment He gave me is totally out of proportion to the crime I committed."

"You took my life."

"Have you any idea how many men have taken the lives of other men? Do they all wander the Earth, meting out punishment to those who perform acts of force? I don't think so, or the world would not be overrun by violence."

"No," admitted my brother. "You are the only one. The others have other punishments."

"So I am the only one condemned to right wrongs and defend the defenseless?"

"It is not a condemnation, my brother. It may have felt like a punishment, but it is a high calling that has cleansed your soul. Otherwise I would not be here to present God's offer."

I considered his words for a long moment.

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"Nonsense," I said. "We are what we are. You were made a victim, and I was made a killer. If I were not avenging acts of violence, I would be perpetrating them."

"But this need not be!" protested Abel. "God loves you!"

"If God loves me, I shudder to think what He does to those He merely likes!"

"I shall curse your name as long as I live, Cain!"

"That won't be as long as you think, my brother," I said, approaching him with a grim smile on my lips.

It was over in a matter of seconds. The police will round up the usual suspects, and they may even convict one of them of my crime, but since I have no true existence, no fingerprints, no thick file in their headquarters, they will never know what truly happened.

Just before I vanished, I felt His voice inside my head: Thou hast broken thy covenant with me, Child of Perdition! From this day forth, until Judgment Day, thou shalt be an outcast to My kingdom, and thy only existence shall be as the

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Children's Avenger!

Blessing or curse, it all depends on your point of view.

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